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Teaching History from an Indigenous Perspective Four Winding Paths up the Mountain

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For Aboriginal students, history courses in Canadian schools are probably the most difficult. The problems are not simply a matter of the lack of inclusion of Native content and that Aboriginal students must endure readings and discussions that still regard their ancestors as part of the conquest of a wilderness tamed in the making of a civilized nation. Rather, the deeper problem is that the categories of what counts as history do not often correspond with the ways that traditional indigenous communities make meaning out of the past. While revisionist and more inclusive histories have brought the experiences of indigenous peoples into a more public conversation about social justice and the consequences of “nation building” as colonization, the deeper perspectives of Aboriginal peoples in regard to their understandings of the processes of time and the principles of their knowledge systems are usually missing.

In this chapter, I discuss four themes of indigenous historical consciousness that travel outside of ways that history courses are constructed and taught. These themes reverberate around the ways that indigenous elders, traditional knowledge specialists, and Native scholars have referenced the past to communicate truths and identities that bind their worlds together. The predicament in the teaching of history from an indigenous perspective has not just been the application of the “selective tradition,” as Raymond Williams puts it, which selects the facts and stories; it lies more in the ways

that the stories are told and in the purposes of the stories. Cherokee author Thomas King has written that “the truth about stories is that that’s all we are.”¹ There is a deep and dangerous purpose in narrating the past, and indigenous people understood this well. A wrongly told story – and by this I do not mean strictly inaccurate – could have devastating consequences for a village, since people made important survival decisions based on their reading of the environment and on the oral traditions that referenced sacred relationships with the ecologies of the past.

Remembering the ways my grandfather talked about time, landscapes, and animals, and my work with Coast Salish communities in British Columbia and Washington State, has taught me a great deal about how the past is understood and experienced in indigenous communities. Four themes of indigenous ways of understanding the past that are difficult to integrate into the conventions of Western historiographies have to do with (1) the circular nature of time and the ways oral tradition is integrated with recurring events – notions of “progress” are problematic in this way of understanding history; (2) the often central theme of relationships with landscape and non-humans; (3) an emphasis on the local landscape as containing the meaning of both time and place rather than on analyses of global social and political change; and (4) indigenous narratives and perspectives on the histories of colonization that have attempted to displace and replace indigenous knowledge.

These concepts have been central concerns of the indigenous scholars who have emerged in the past twenty years to challenge the assumptions of Western epistemologies and interpretations of the past. The focus on decolonization and the assertion of indigenous meanings have been challenges for historians and history teachers wanting to find common ground with historiographies that seem to be worlds apart. The crisis in confidence that has plagued history, anthropology, and even the sciences, as a result of indigenous voices “writing back” to the empire, has not produced changes in the way history is understood and taught in schools outside of universities. These four themes of indigenous historiography are all integrated; but to use an indigenous metaphor, they can be thought of as intersecting paths up a mountain. Many indigenous peoples have sacred mountains and other revered sites within their traditional territories. These are places where important stories happened, many of them related to the creation of the world. In systems of place-based traditional knowledge, stories are located in these spots on the physical landscape. Elders often refer to the many paths that one takes to arrive at the top of the mountain. Each path constitutes a physical *and* metaphysical journey. Comprehending indigenous ways of seeing the

past requires travelling these intellectual trails up an indigenous mountain and leaving behind some of the expectations about what constitutes “history” from a Western mindset.

In classrooms, Aboriginal students come up against an almost impenetrable wall of historical “facts,” which teachers deliver in tightly sealed conceptual boxes. Aboriginal students who sometimes question these “facts” can be regarded as disruptive to educational processes. One of my Aboriginal graduate students told me how questioning historical “facts” in a public school history classroom was a “defining moment” in her educational experience. The teacher was explaining the early origins of Aboriginal peoples in Canada by telling the students that the Bering Land Bridge enabled the early “Aboriginal immigrants” to cross to North America. The graduate student remembered asking “if they had left footprints, or a note, or something. How do we really know this for sure?” She was questioning the “truth” of the official explanation: an explanation that contradicted the creation stories of human origins from her own Aboriginal community. The teacher insisted that the class had gone over the ways in which scientific evidence shows the reality of the past, but the Aboriginal student continued to be dissatisfied with an official history that placed her ancestors as part of someone else’s story of the past – and as immigrants. The student told me: “I remember being punished by having to stand in the corner.”

In many ways, this story of an Aboriginal student’s “defining moment” in schooling reveals much about the problems of cross-cultural communication in the classroom as they relate to interpretations of history. Aboriginal children who are raised to respect the traditions of their communities grow up hearing elders tell creation stories of how the people were placed on the land by the Creator. These stories are not the same as religious traditions that clash with teleologies of modernist education. They are narratives that define the meaning of the *local* geography. These stories are told in ways that expose deep truths about the people’s responsibilities and relationships to the land. There is a fundamental difference between a story that places people as coming *to* the land and a story that has people coming *from* the land. Vine Deloria is the scholar most recognized for his critiques of the Bering Land Bridge theories. While all indigenous academics are familiar with Deloria’s work, social studies and history teachers in schools usually are not aware of iconoclastic Native scholarship. Too many teachers are seldom aware of writings that contradict accepted school-based knowledge about the past. Deloria has articulated what is often felt but not said by Aboriginal students in classrooms: “By making us immigrants to North

America they are able to deny the fact that we were the full, complete, and total owners of this continent. They are able to see us simply as earlier interlopers and therefore throw back at us the accusation that we had simply *found* North America a little earlier than they had.”²

Deloria, like other indigenous writers and community leaders, understands the concrete consequences of how students are taught the history of Aboriginal peoples. The self-determination efforts of First Nations communities are part of a larger movement toward decolonization. When Aboriginal students are told that their cultural interpretation of history is not the correct one, the hegemony of this moment is often internalized. This deteriorates the ability of indigenous communities to organize around their own epistemologies. Mi'kmaq scholar Marie Battiste has called this “cognitive imperialism.” She has pointed out that the processes of colonization through education have produced “cognitive prisons” for Aboriginal students.³

Circular Time and Linear Time

Many indigenous scholars have referred to the contrasts and even contradictions between indigenous and Western understandings of time and reality. This is often discussed as the difference between circular and linear conceptions of time. Donald Fixico, an indigenous historian, has explained that “to understand Indian people and their ways of life, it is evident that the ‘circle’ occupies an integral role in the beliefs of American Indians.”⁴ He goes on to point out differences in “thinking” between Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal peoples: “From an opposing point of view, the linear way of thinking and perceiving the world is the non-Indian way that Native Americans have had to learn in schools and while working with other Americans ... Their philosophies, ideologies, logic, and world views proved distinctively different due to the separate evolutions of the human mind set in the Eastern Hemisphere and Western Hemisphere during the pre-Columbian era.”⁵

Linguist Benjamin Whorf, in his work with the Hopi, is probably the best-known scholar for seeing the connections among cognition, language, and conceptions of time. Whorf wrote that for the Hopi, “time is not a motion but a ‘getting later’ of everything that has ever been done.”⁶ History, from an indigenous point of view, then, is not a linear progression of people and ideas in time, but rather a spiralling of events and themes that appear and reappear within circles of seasons and that are identified in oral traditions. Of course, this does not mean that indigenous historical thought has

no way of accounting for changes over time; it is only that the changes in both human societies and landscapes include characters and contexts that circulate to merge eras together in a non-linear fashion.

As Whorf discovered indigenous conceptions of time through linguistics, Julie Cruikshank and other anthropologists doing work on oral history and oral tradition have described the contemporary presence and utility of the circular way of understanding the indigenous past. Cruikshank, drawing on the views of Canadian historian Harold Innis, points to ways that oral tradition has the “potential to counterbalance mechanical segmentation of time and space.”⁷ In her work with Aboriginal elders in Yukon, Cruikshank collected stories that shifted back and forth in time and that did not respond to Western categories of past, present, mythos,⁸ and fact. Recognizing that the past is culturally constituted and culturally narrated, she listened to elders tell stories about the 1940s that included individuals from oral traditions hundreds of years before that era. The sense of linear time was folded and curved to account for the merging of events and characters; this created a circular and recurring moral universe within an indigenous epistemology. “These narratives erased any distinction between ‘story’ and ‘history.’”⁹

Indigenous historiographies that emphasize the circular patterns of time are essential components of a decolonizing curriculum for Aboriginal students and schools. One of the central goals of First Nations communities is to “bring back” pre-contact knowledge and values that integrate these understandings of space and time into a contemporary curriculum that fortifies a sense of Aboriginal identity in the youth. Moving away from a linear version of time and toward an indigenous way of understanding the past reinforces the community’s ways of thinking about social organization and identity. Indigenous world views tend to emphasize the moral and spiritual structure of events. These are immersed in recurring stories that circulate to bind reality together. The linear version of time, associated with Eurocentric values, as Leroy Littlebear points out, “manifests itself in terms of bigger, higher, newer, or faster being preferred over smaller, lower, older, or slower.”¹⁰ From an indigenous perspective, the assumptions of “progress” that are inextricable from both modernity and hierarchical categories that emerged from colonization are in collision with a circular cosmology that sees new shapes of reality as returning versions of both ancestors and ideas. History curricula for schools in Canada have emphasized notions of progress that tend to relegate First Nations to a primitive past on a timeline leading to a more progressive present era.

Indigenous language teachers have often explained to me how important the circular experience of time is in bringing the languages back into a contemporary context. To make the languages a vital part of the place-based identities of Aboriginal students, the stories, place names, and moral understandings from ancestors must be integrated into the contemporary experience that youth have with their present socio-economic conditions. The contemporary experience of Aboriginal youth includes the dominance of digital technology and media. Language revival, for Aboriginal communities, requires an engagement with the natural ecology such that the oral traditions and mental maps of the landscape are recycled from the past into the present consciousness. Indigenous elders understand the connection between landscapes and mindscapes for future generations. The language comes from the land, and learning the language builds a cognitive geography of the traditional territory. Indigenous languages are often referred to as “verb oriented” rather than “noun oriented.” This is related to the sense that words describe a universe in constant motion, a “doing” rather than a “being” in the world. This is also connected to the concept of circular time such that reality moves in and out of present and past and the language captures the dynamism of this revolving motion.

Relationships with Landscape and Non-Humans

While Canadian history textbooks and courses usually include some discussion of plants and animals, this inquiry is usually limited to considerations of the socio-economic effects of certain plants and animals as resources for human exploitation. For example, histories of the fur trade era would probably include a discussion of the importance of the beaver, and the history of British Columbia would include information about the value of the salmon fishery to both Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal societies. Indigenous systems of knowledge and understandings of the past are different from these approaches in that they place animals as unsegmented from human beings. Many indigenous traditions recognize the animals as having been created first and therefore as being older and wiser than humans. From an indigenous perspective, much of the knowledge of the past *came* from the relationships that human beings developed with animals. The histories of tribal people are filled with stories of how particular animals sacrificed and taught the human communities. In these narratives, the sacred ecology of animals and humans and the sustaining cycles of life are explained. Many of these stories demonstrate the reasons for particular seasonal ceremonies. Among

Coast Salish peoples, for instance, the First Salmon Ceremony is conducted each year to honour the Salmon People who sacrifice themselves to feed the villages. The stories of how the people originally came to have the fish are told, and the respectful relationship between salmon and humans is affirmed in the stories and ceremonies. The salmon are not just a resource that can be traced historically; they are integrated into all aspects of the past, present, and future for the Coast Salish people. Relationships between animals and humans are central to indigenous approaches to history.

These ways of understanding relationships to animals are more than simply metaphorical frames of reference about cultures in the past. They are essential concepts for understanding treaty negotiations and present-day land claims – concepts predicated on the ways people used and took care of their land. A history text that explains Aboriginal starvation and dislocation as a result of the extermination of the bison on the Plains does not usually account for the loss of a deep spiritual webbing between humans and the buffalo. The physical and metaphysical materials for an entire way of life were lost when the buffalo were exterminated by Western “progress.” Moreover, it is difficult to explain, within Eurocentric frames of reference, the deeper goals and purposes of indigenous communities that are trying to reclaim ancient relationships to culturally important animals through a combination of modern and pre-modern means. Inuit seal hunts and efforts to return to hunting whales for groups like the Nuuchah-nulth and Makah are often misunderstood by the public.¹¹ These self-determination moves on the part of First Nations are based on understandings of how their own histories are inextricably linked to particular animals. Indigenous leaders see the prospects of healing the social and economic woes of their communities by reconnecting the links to relationships with animals that sustained the people in the past.

Approaches to history that show indigenous peoples’ relationships to plants and animals are some first steps toward recognizing a deeper sense of how, as traditional people often put it, “the land knows you’re there.” Julie Cruikshank has used the term “sentient landscape” to refer to the ways in which human beings in pre-contact times formed relationships with geographic and geologic entities that recognized the presence and conduct of people. Discussing the problems of Eurocentric binaries such as *mythos* and history, Cruikshank writes that the Aboriginal women who explained aspects of Yukon’s past to her did not make rigid distinctions between historical truth and moral and cultural truth: “The stories these women tell

summon up a moral system that includes relationships with non-humans – animals and also features of landscape, like glaciers – that share characteristics of personhood.”¹² It is clear that narrating the past is a selective and creative process that calls upon the cultural conventions of maintaining particular boundaries of thought. It is not that indigenous approaches to the past do not have categories of explanation for events and meanings; it is that these categories do not necessarily correspond to Western intellectual frameworks and purposes. Indigenous historical narratives place human beings in a landscape that is understood to have mythic forms converging with everyday forms of experience. Many Aboriginal communities are familiar with hearing the past narrated in this seamless fashion, which places mythic and moral understandings alongside genealogies that include animals and culturally important places on the landscape. Histories include moral teachings from encounters with animals such as Owl, Raven, Wolf, and Bear. For a number of indigenous groups in Canada, these animals have important spiritual connections to families and clans. Thus, a history that ignores animals is, to a certain extent, a disrespectful and incomplete telling of the past.

An indigenous perspective on animals and the “sentient landscape” could be included in a history text, but the hegemony of modernity in historiography tends to marginalize these narratives as myth, legend, or “alternative” ways of thinking; as a consequence, they end up being treated as “subalternate” ways of seeing the world. At the same time, indigenous historical narratives that combine oral traditions with ecological knowledge have informed environmental scientists about ways of seeing reciprocity among animals, humans, and changing landscapes. Indigenous elders have told stories about the past with the goal of connecting human experience to the ecologies of places. This way of narrating the past is vital for helping youth understand their responsibility for maintaining the place-based traditions that have sustained their communities. In the 1997 *Delgamuukw* decision, the Supreme Court of Canada recognized this use of oral tradition for chronicling the past as an ancient yet also emergent form of legal discourse – one having equivalent power with documentary evidence to demonstrate historic truth. In that decision, oral tradition was given the same weight as written evidence. The Gitksan and Wet’suwet’en Nations were thereby able to demonstrate their occupancy and ownership of their land – 58,000 square kilometres of northern British Columbia – by resorting to their *adaawks*, traditional creation stories.¹³ Those creation stories revealed to the Court how the land and the resources had been maintained through

practices and protocols emphasizing responsibilities to animals, plants, and culturally important sites on the landscape.

By examining indigenous categories that merge human and animal histories, we might rethink the ways in which major events and accomplishments, such as the building of railways and industries, are framed around discourses of “advances” in human society. A history that includes the ways in which the natural ecology was altered and degraded by industrialization is illuminating; but First Nations also focus on how the conditions of “relationship” between humans and animals are affected by the actions of human society. Historians such as William Cronon have made inquiries in this environmental direction, pointing out that the history of colonization in North America was “as much an ecological as a cultural revolution and the human side of that revolution cannot be fully understood until it is embedded in the ecological one. Doing so requires a history not only of human actors, conflicts, and economies, but of ecosystems as well.”¹⁴ Having said that, one of the key differences between an environmental emphasis in historiography and an Aboriginal approach to the histories of humans, animals, and landscapes relates to the blurring of time divisions between the mythic era and the present one. The animals are immersed in a landscape that is at once physical and metaphysical. It is, as Vine Deloria has said, a sacred ecology. The relationships between humans and animals frame this sacred ecology.

Place and Indigenous Understandings of the Local

For indigenous communities, the past is located in the local and traditional territory. Scholars such as Eric R. Wolf have shown how events in Europe intertwined with the events that shaped local indigenous experience through colonization and eventually globalization; by contrast, the indigenous vision of the past is sublimely local.¹⁵ Because history is always a selective telling of the past, indigenous peoples often select the events and meanings of the past from their home territories as the most important stories to tell. This does not mean that Aboriginal communities are unaware of the international forces that have driven colonization; rather, elders and community leaders are more focused on local understandings of political, historical, and cultural processes than on events occurring globally. As one Lummi elder told me: “We have to take care of this place, we won’t be moving to some other place. We are the people from here and we must concern ourselves with protecting our land.” For indigenous people, the local history that frames the community’s relationship to the traditional territory is the most important knowledge to be passed on to the youth.

A significant example of how indigenous communities are focusing on local knowledge of the past is the publication of the Sto:lo Atlas, which is a collaborative effort between the Sto:lo Aboriginal Rights and Title department (AR&T) and a selected group of anthropologists and historians. That atlas provides important information on Sto:lo history, place names, traditional knowledge, identity themes, environmental issues, social structure, and sacred sites. It is replete with photographs, maps, and elaborate graphics. The Sto:lo have decided to carefully publish aspects of their traditional knowledge in order to educate the dominant Canadian society. Editor Keith Thor Carlson's preface explains that the atlas is "a powerful educational tool with application to ongoing Sto:lo Nation treaty negotiations."¹⁶ Such works produced by First Nations can be contentious in Aboriginal *and* non-Aboriginal communities. In British Columbia, versions of regional history that present indigenous interpretations of land occupancy are often rejected by non-Natives in a backlash environment in which there is opposition to the return of stolen land and resources. At the same time, indigenous communities often view the publication of their local traditional knowledge as a kind of Faustian bargain, in the sense that intricate understandings that have been kept within a small circle become public knowledge for the sake of greater social acceptance of Aboriginal values and social justice perspectives. While the goal of the atlas is to educate Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal audiences alike about S'ólh Téméxw (Sto:lo territory), it is a problem for Coast Salish communities to publish information about sacred sites and traditional knowledge. In the case of the atlas, elders were consulted and the text was carefully chosen so as to not reveal knowledge protected by community protocols. It is especially a problem to publish information about ceremonies and personal understandings regarding such things as winter spirit dancing. Spiritual danger is associated with speaking publicly about personal knowledge and sacred rituals. Coast Salish families who participate in private longhouse ceremonies are taught not to discuss what goes on during these rituals.

In many respects, presenting local history from an indigenous perspective is one of the most politically difficult educational moves to be made in developing culturally responsive curricula. Elizabeth Furniss has explained the ways that, especially in rural communities, the "frontier myth" emphasizing progress is resistant to more diverse and inclusive approaches to the past. She discusses how, in British Columbia, a course on First Nations history and culture has been created to provide secondary students with a less

ethnocentric view of Aboriginal people and the history of colonization. With its strong emphasis on critical thinking, colonialism's legacy, and the role of land claims in the province's economic future, the course can seem somewhat iconoclastic: indigenous people are not simply a feature of the past; they are a pivotal group both within and apart from Canadian society. Placing history in the role of challenging the assumptions about the present-day identity stories of a nation or a region is particularly contentious in high school settings, where youth are approaching adulthood directed by values and beliefs that have been cemented throughout childhood. Furniss explains both the imperative and the tension: "That such a curriculum was deemed necessary for British Columbia is undoubtedly a reflection of the growing prominence of First Nations issues in the media and in the courts, and the rising tension between Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal peoples over impending treaty settlements."¹⁷ Furniss has shown how local historical interpretations are dominated by the social and economic hegemony of discourses around commerce and tourism. In British Columbia, towns celebrate their colourful pasts and the important families that contributed to the development of modern community life. A local history that includes First Nations voices has the potential to challenge old assumptions about the community's identity. For local indigenous people, the narratives of progress that are celebrated in chronicles of the development of industries and the economic benefits generated by local natural resources contain "inaudible" stories of the displacement and marginalization of Aboriginal life.

One reason that a local telling of the past is so controversial in places like British Columbia is that the stage play of history is so personal and intimate in this local context. First Nations communities and settler immigrant communities are living these histories in the present controversies about ethics and identities. Aboriginal communities on the fringes of these towns raise questions about the conduct of the newcomers and about how the world became so divided – and degraded. The past in such places is not remote; it is being challenged and struggled for locally as the names of rivers, mountains, and culturally important sites are renamed in indigenous languages. These stories of the local collide with Eurocentric assumptions about the conduct of pioneer ancestors. In examining the use of local histories to supplement nationalist histories, Furniss has pointed to how seamless the historiographical approach is in both kinds of texts. In local *and* national narratives, the role of the Native is subordinated and shaped by the need to narrate a selective story that silences dissenting indigenous voices:

These books are united by their common situation within the frontier myth. They focus almost exclusively on the challenges and triumphs of pioneers and colonial systems. Natives are either invisible in these histories or are scripted as supporting characters in images that are negative, quaint, child-like, and/or passive. These books, by their sheer volume, constitute a dominant historical discourse that cannot but pervade the consciousness of the general population.¹⁸

Aboriginal storytellers have often wanted their local narratives of the past to inform the settler societies about dangerous ecological conditions and the consequences of bad choices in industrialization and development. I attended a conference held in Seattle on salmon and environmental problems where a Yakima elder told the traditional story of Coyote and the Swallow Sisters as a way to explain how his people came to know that dams on rivers were ecologically and morally wrong. In the story, Coyote must help the starving human beings by destroying a dam that has been built by two greedy sisters who wish to keep all the salmon for themselves. Coyote undergoes a number of transformations in order to accomplish this. In the end, he changes the sisters into swallows and leaves the presence of the birds and the story as a kind of text written on the landscape to inform future generations of the consequences of bad ecological and ethical choices.

In her work with Okanagan elder Harry Robinson, Wendy Wickwire gives us another example of how local traditional knowledge, from an indigenous perspective, is not supplementary, but rather a central core of history. The stories perform a teaching task that illuminates culture conflict themes in Aboriginal–non-Aboriginal relations:

Harry told his nature power stories to set straight the historical record so that everyone, Native and non-Native alike, would know why Whites and Indians are different. He was concerned that the deep knowledge of the past was disappearing ... Harry also believed his stories would help people, both Native and White, to understand where they came from and why their interactions have been so antagonistic.¹⁹

For indigenous communities, local history and traditional ecological knowledge provide the template for their expressions of identity and self-determination. Local and regional histories often provide the detail and complexity that can break down the persistent stereotyping of the “Native other.”

Colonization and the House of Murky Mirrors

The stereotypes of the “drunken Indian” and the “lazy Indian” are part of the legacy of colonization. Unravelling some of the complexities of the collision of world views is one of the most difficult yet also essential tasks in efforts to present indigenous ways of making meaning from the past. Too often the history of Aboriginal–white relations in Canada is presented as a melodramatic morality play casting the Native people as victims of progress and as unwilling to adapt to the social transformations of the nineteenth century. More recent attempts to show some previously neglected aspects of nation building and colonization, such as residential schooling and racism, are too often oversimplifications of a story filled with ironies and paradoxes. Historian John Lutz has shown that the Coast Salish people of British Columbia responded to the conditions of nineteenth- and twentieth-century colonization by using wage labour opportunities provided by the logging and fishing industries to develop their own culturally structured economies.²⁰ Aboriginal people were not lazy; rather, they used money from employment toward economic goals connected with the “prestige economies” of the potlatch. Their cultural goals were different from those of white society; their choices about making and spending money reflected a world view that the dominant society could neither understand nor accept. Missionaries and government agents tried to promote individual acquisition of wealth among Aboriginal communities as a necessary step toward assimilation. Colonization involved more than taking away Native space; it was a complex struggle to redefine the goals and purposes of life. Indigenous people responded, not by refusing to participate, but by participating in the new forms of economic life within the cultural sensibilities of their own collectivist cultures.

To white observers, it often seemed as if Aboriginal peoples were eager to abandon their traditional ways of life and become crude versions of Euro-Canadians. So it is often difficult for students to understand how quickly indigenous communities adopted Christianity. What is often ignored is how indigenous cultures sometimes resisted but at other times adapted new ideas and new forms that could supplement traditional religious practices without replacing them. Many First Nations amalgamated Christianity into traditional spiritual beliefs, creating new religious practices that often frustrated missionaries but that worked well in the context of the new and complex realities of colonization. This is an example of the labyrinthine history of indigenous community responses to overwhelming forces of assimilation and transformation. Clearly, indigenous peoples never responded to colonization in one-dimensional ways.

For indigenous communities and indigenous scholars, the legacy of colonization is an important point of reference not just for understanding the sources of confusing present social conditions, but for framing the ideological divide that must be navigated in the course of decolonization. Re-interpreting this history has been a central goal of many indigenous scholars, who understand how deeply the past is implicated in the unresolved issues of identity and injustice. Linda Smith has written about the messy business of struggling for an alternative, indigenized history:

Our colonial experience traps us in the project of modernity. There can be no “postmodern” for us until we have settled some business of the modern. This does not mean that we do not understand or employ multiple discourses, or act in incredibly contradictory ways, or exercise power ourselves in multiple ways. It means that there is unfinished business, that we are still being colonized (and know it), and that we are still searching for justice ... Transforming our colonized views of our own history (as written by the West), however, requires us to revisit, site by site, our history under Western eyes.²¹

For indigenous peoples, a history of Canada as a nation-state is a colonizing way of thinking about people, relationships, and land. This situation is amplified for Aboriginal groups such as the Coast Salish, whose traditional territory was divided by the border between Canada and the United States. Elders and Coast Salish leaders see the need to reimplant a cognitive geography in the minds of youth to help them see the pre-contact world of connected villages across imposed borders. Some community leaders are encouraging youth to think of themselves as Coast Salish rather than Canadians or Americans. People are intermarrying across the border, and many have lived on both sides of the line and are affiliated with two or more communities. Paige Raibmon has explained that “when the Canada–U.S. boundary sliced intervillage communities in two, many of the required journeys became border crossings. Coast Salish, who travelled from British Columbia to Washington, re-entered a familiar orbit of extended kin more than they entered a foreign country.”²²

For these indigenous communities, a history of their own “borderless” territory from the perspective of their own traditional way of seeing space is a more decolonizing approach to understanding the past than a telling of how nation-states fought with each other over how to divide Coast Salish land. It will be more than difficult to reconcile a history curriculum that

seeks to inculcate national identity and citizenship with indigenous desires to assert sovereignty and reclaim pre-contact understandings of time and space.

History will likely continue to be one of the most difficult subjects for Aboriginal students because of its embedded assumptions about progress and modernity. For history teachers who want to include indigenous perspectives, the metaphor of the four winding paths up the mountain may contain some practical hints about what is needed to change things. A common principle among indigenous peoples is that when one approaches a sacred site, such as a mountain, knowledge acquisition requires some form of sacrifice. Teachers who want to be more inclusive toward indigenous perspectives will have to acquire the time-space in classrooms for considering the four themes of an indigenous historical consciousness; this will necessarily entail sacrificing some conventional ways of teaching Canadian history. Including indigenous principles in history curricula could inspire students to imagine alternative ways to structure the societies of the future as a result of learning about indigenous ways of experiencing time and space. Indigenous historical consciousness is a holistic and interdisciplinary way of understanding reality. The four themes in this endeavour – (1) circular time, (2) relationships with land and animals, (3) local knowledge, and (4) the complexities of colonization and decolonization – have been core concerns for Aboriginal communities and scholars. Including these considerations in Canadian history texts and courses will require a shift in the goals and purposes of studying history. If we can begin to see the land and the flow of stories from the land as part of a past that carries us on a common journey, the way indigenous people view history may help schools reconfigure our relationships to the ecologies of our communities and revise our thinking about how to live sustainably in the future.

NOTES

- 1 Thomas King, *The Truth about Stories: A Native Narrative*, CBC Massey Lectures Series (Toronto: House of Anansi Press, 2003), 2.
- 2 Vine Deloria, *Red Earth, White Lies: Native Americans and the Myth of Scientific Fact* (New York: Scribner's, 1995), 84.
- 3 Marie Battiste, *Introduction to Reclaiming Indigenous Voice and Vision* (Vancouver: UBC Press, 2000), xvii.
- 4 Donald Fixico, *The American Indian Mind in a Linear World: American Indian Studies and Traditional Knowledge* (London: Routledge, 2003), 42.
- 5 Ibid., 45.

- 6 Benjamin Whorf, "The Relation of Habitual Thought and Behavior to Language," in *Language, Culture, and Personality: Essays in Memory of Edward Sapir*, ed. Leslie Spier (Menasha: Sapir Memorial Publication Fund, 1941), 209. <http://sloan.stanford.edu>.
- 7 Julie Cruikshank, "Oral History, Narrative Strategies, and Native American Historiography: Perspectives from the Yukon Territory, Canada," in *Clearing a Path: Theorizing the Past in Native American Studies*, ed. Nancy Shoemaker (London: Routledge, 2002), 7.
- 8 *Mythos*, in this sense, refers to the stories that define the interrelations among spirits, landscapes, animals, and humans.
- 9 *Ibid.*, 13.
- 10 Leroy Littlebear, "Jagged Worldviews Colliding," in *Reclaiming Indigenous Voice and Vision* (Vancouver: UBC Press, 2000), 82.
- 11 See Michael Marker, "After the Makah Whalehunt: Indigenous Knowledge and Limits to Multicultural Discourse," *Urban Education* 41, 5 (September 2006): 1-24.
- 12 Julie Cruikshank, *Do Glaciers Listen? Local Knowledge, Colonial Encounters, and Social Imagination* (Vancouver: UBC Press, 2005), 60.
- 13 See Patrick Macklem, *Indigenous Difference and the Constitution of Canada* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2002).
- 14 William Cronon, *Changes in the Land: Indians, Colonists, and the Ecology of New England* (New York: Hill and Wang, 1983), 6.
- 15 Eric Wolf, *Europe and the People without History* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1982).
- 16 Keith T. Carlson and Sonny McHalsie, *A Sto:lo Coast Salish Historical Atlas* (Vancouver: Douglas and McIntyre, 2001), xv.
- 17 Elizabeth Furniss, "Pioneers, Progress, and the Myth of the Frontier," *BC Studies* 115-16 (1997-98): 20.
- 18 *Ibid.*, 33.
- 19 Wendy Wickwire, *Nature Power: In the Spirit of an Okanagan Storyteller* (Vancouver: Douglas and McIntyre, 1992), 14-15.
- 20 John Lutz, *Makuk: A New History of Aboriginal-White Relations* (Vancouver: UBC Press, 2008).
- 21 Linda Smith, *Decolonizing Methodologies: Research and Indigenous Peoples* (London: Zed Books, 1999), 34.
- 22 Paige Raibmon, *Authentic Indians: Episodes of Encounter from the Late-Nineteenth-Century Northwest Coast* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2005), 109.